ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 411: Theatre Research, Seminar and Long Essay

From a topic idea to a bound, defensible final-year essay

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 400L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

The department's long essay is a supervised research project with a defined format. This pack covers choosing a topic, research questions, literature review, methodology for practice-based and text-based work, seminar presentation, the MLA style the department specifies, and the submission schedule.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Turn a broad interest into a focused research question.
- Write a literature review that positions your study.
- Choose a method appropriate to text-based, practice-based or audience research.
- Present a seminar and submit a correctly formatted long essay.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Topic and research question

A topic is a field; a research question is an argument you can finish.

- Start from a problem you can state in one sentence.
- Narrow by text, production, period, audience or practice.
- Check that sources and access exist before committing.
- Write a question answerable with evidence you can actually gather.
- Agree the title with your supervisor early.
- Keep a research log of decisions and supervisor comments.

Literature and method

The review positions you; the method tells the reader how you will answer.

- Group sources by debate, not by author-by-author summary.
- Identify the gap your study addresses.
- Textual analysis: close reading supported by theory.
- Practice-based research: document process, decisions and reflection.
- Audience or field research: sampling, instruments, consent and ethics.
- Be explicit about limitations rather than overclaiming.

> **MLA, as specified**
> The department style manual specifies MLA. Use in-text parenthetical citations and a Works Cited page, and check every entry against the source.

Seminar and submission

The calendar is part of the assessment.

- Draft a proposal: title, question, rationale, method, chapter outline, bibliography.
- Present a seminar with slides that show argument, not paragraphs.
- Expect challenging questions and record the feedback.
- Submit chapters progressively to your supervisor.
- Proofread for citation consistency and formatting.
- Meet the binding and submission deadline; late work risks non-assessment.

From interest to a researchable topic

A topic is not a subject. "Costume in Nigerian theatre" is a subject and will produce an unfocused essay. A topic names a specific case, a specific question and a specific claim: "How does costume construction in the Aba carnival negotiate between masquerade convention and commercial spectacle?" That version tells you what to read, what to observe and what to argue.

Narrow in three steps. First choose a case you can actually access - a production, a company, a festival, a set of scripts, a venue. Then choose an angle: historical, textual, production-based, reception-based or practice-based. Finally choose a question that your material can answer. Access is not a compromise; it is the condition of evidence.

Test the topic with three questions: what will I read, what will I observe or collect, and what would count as a finding? If any answer is vague, the topic is still a subject.

Method, evidence and the literature review